

A FREE GUIDE FOR BUYERS AND RELOCATING FAMILIES

THE EAST TENNESSEE HOME BUYER'S GUIDE

Knoxville and the surrounding communities, explained by a local who has done this for hundreds of families.

WELCOME

WHY A LOCAL GUIDE MATTERS



Hi, I'm Tiana. I've helped **over 300 families** relocate to, sell in and settle across East Tennessee. I know the neighborhoods, the builders, the lenders, the school zones and the quirks of every county, and that knowledge is what protects your time and your money.

Anyone can show you a listing. A true local tells you what the listing doesn't: how the commute really feels at 5 p.m., which streets flood, where the new development is headed, and what a fair price looks like *on that street*, not just in that zip code.

300+
families helped with relocation and selling

8 yrs
in real estate, 20+ years in sales and marketing

5-star
client reviews on Google

WHAT A LOCAL EXPERT DOES FOR YOU

- **Matches the lifestyle,** not just the house. Tell me how you live now and I'll find where it fits here.
- **Knows the real costs:** property taxes, utility districts, insurance and HOA dues by area.
- **Spots problems early:** flood zones, septic and well, steep lots, easements and road access.
- **Prices accurately** using neighborhood-level sales, so you don't overpay.
- **Negotiates from experience** with local agents, sellers and builders.
- **Coordinates the team:** trusted lenders, inspectors, surveyors, attorneys and movers.

MOVING FROM OUT OF STATE?

I help relocating buyers every month: virtual tours and video walk-throughs, neighborhood drive-throughs on camera, and a tightly planned visit so one trip is enough to find your home. Ask me how it works.

START HERE

YOUR HOME SEARCH QUESTIONNAIRE

Check what fits and jot notes. Bring it to our first call, or send it back to me. The more I know, the better I can match you.

1. WHERE ARE YOU COMING FROM?

2. WHAT DO YOU LOVE ABOUT WHERE YOU LIVE NOW?

☐ Walkable / city energy ☐ Quiet suburb ☐ Water / lake ☐ Mountains / trails ☐ Land / privacy
☐ Great schools ☐ Dining & culture ☐ Warm weather

3. WHO IS MOVING?

☐ Just me ☐ Couple ☐ Family with kids ☐ Multi-generational ☐ Pets ☐ Working from home

4. WHICH AREAS INTEREST YOU?

☐ Downtown / Old City ☐ West Knoxville ☐ Farragut ☐ Hardin Valley ☐ South Knoxville
☐ North Knox / Powell ☐ Maryville / Alcoa ☐ Oak Ridge ☐ Sevierville ☐ Townsend
☐ Lenoir City / Loudon ☐ Lake living ☐ Not sure yet

5. TYPE OF HOME

☐ Single-family ☐ Townhome / condo ☐ New construction ☐ Historic / character ☐ Acreage / farm
☐ Cabin / mountain ☐ Waterfront

6. TOP 5 MUST-HAVES

7. DEALBREAKERS

8. COMFORTABLE MONTHLY PAYMENT

9. DOWN PAYMENT AVAILABLE

10. MOVE-IN TIMELINE

☐ 0-3 mo ☐ 3-6 mo ☐ 6-12 mo ☐ Exploring

11. PRE-APPROVED?

☐ Yes ☐ Not yet ☐ Need a lender

12. PLANS FOR THE PROPERTY

☐ Primary home ☐ Guest house / ADU ☐ Home office / studio ☐ Workshop / barn ☐ Hobby farm
☐ Short-term rental ☐ Long-term rental ☐ Add a pool / expand ☐ Build / subdivide

13. DO YOU NEED TO SELL A HOME FIRST?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Already sold

KNOW YOUR NUMBERS

WHY BUDGETING COMES FIRST

The biggest mistake buyers make is shopping for the price a lender approves instead of the payment that feels good. Being **approved** for a loan and being **comfortable** with a payment are two different numbers. A clear budget protects you from stress, from overbidding and from surprises after closing.

YOUR TRUE MONTHLY COST

ITEM	WHAT TO KNOW
Principal & interest	The loan payment. Rate, term and down payment drive it.
Property taxes	Vary by county and city. Check the actual tax bill for any home you like, and remember a sale can change the assessment.
Homeowner's insurance	Costs differ by age, roof, and location. Get quotes before you offer.
Flood / other insurance	Required in flood zones. Mountain and wooded areas may carry different risks.
Mortgage insurance	Often applies with less than 20% down.
HOA / community fees	Can include amenities, roads, or lake access. Ask what's covered.
Utilities & internet	Larger or older homes and rural properties can cost more.
Maintenance	Plan to set aside money every month for repairs and upkeep.

CASH YOU'LL NEED UP FRONT

- Down payment
- Earnest money deposit
- Inspection, appraisal and survey
- Closing costs, often a few percent of the price
- Moving costs and first-month setup

SMART BUDGETING HABITS

- Keep an emergency reserve after closing
- Don't open new credit before you close
- Compare at least 3 lenders
- Ask about down payment help, including programs from the Tennessee Housing Development Agency (THDA)

YOUR BUDGET WORKSHEET

Monthly take-home income: _____

Down payment: _____

Emergency reserve: _____

Comfortable monthly payment: _____

Closing cost cushion: _____

Target price range: _____

Use the mortgage calculator at tianawinter.com/buy to test different prices, rates and down payments. Figures are estimates; confirm details with your lender.

KNOXVILLE & CLOSE-IN AREAS

East Tennessee sits between the Great Smoky Mountains and the Cumberland Plateau, with rivers, lakes and ridges running through every community. These are general impressions to start the conversation; every street is different, so let's tour what fits you.

DOWNTOWN KNOXVILLE & OLD CITY

Urban, walkable and lively, with restaurants, music, the riverfront, festivals and condos, lofts and historic homes. Best for people who want energy at their door.

NORTH KNOXVILLE & FOUNTAIN CITY

Established neighborhoods with character homes, tree-lined streets and a growing local food and shop scene close to downtown.

SEQUOYAH HILLS & BEARDEN

Central, established and convenient. Mature trees, riverside greenway access, shopping, dining and easy reach to the university and downtown.

SOUTH KNOXVILLE

The "SoKno" side of the river. Trails, mountain-biking, river views and a creative, outdoorsy feel just minutes from downtown, with a mix of older homes and newer builds.

WEST KNOXVILLE & CEDAR BLUFF

Suburban convenience with shopping, dining, medical and a wide range of home styles and price points.

FARRAGUT

A popular family suburb in west Knox County known for planned neighborhoods, parks, schools and community events. Many buyers moving from other states start here.

HARDIN VALLEY

Newer neighborhoods and growth, close to Pellissippi Parkway and the area's tech and research employers. Good fit for newer construction and commuters to Oak Ridge.

POWELL, HALLS & KARNS

North and northwest suburbs with approachable pricing, newer subdivisions and quick interstate access.

SEYMOUR & EAST KNOX COUNTY

Rolling countryside with more room to breathe, larger lots and views toward the Smokies, with a quick drive into town.

SURROUNDING COMMUNITIES

MARYVILLE & ALCOA (BLOUNT COUNTY)

A strong small-city feel with a charming downtown, a college, parks and greenways, and the foothills of the Smokies. Home to the region's airport, with a wide mix of homes from in-town to acreage.

TOWNSEND & WALLAND

The quiet "peaceful side" of the Smokies. Cabins, creeks, land and mountain views for those who want nature at the doorstep.

OAK RIDGE

A distinctive city with Manhattan Project history, national laboratory and research employers, greenways, and a variety of mid-century and newer homes.

SEVIERVILLE, PIGEON FORGE & GATLINBURG

Gateway to the Smokies and the region's tourism hub. Options range from in-town homes to mountain cabins and investment properties. Short-term rental rules vary, so we'll check before you buy.

LENOIR CITY, LOUDON & TELLICO VILLAGE

Lake and river living on the Tennessee River system with marinas, golf and 55+ amenity communities. Popular with retirees and with buyers who want water access.

JEFFERSON CITY, DANDRIDGE & DOUGLAS LAKE

Small-town living east of Knoxville with lake access, boating and room to spread out, at friendly price points.

UNION & ANDERSON COUNTIES (NORRIS LAKE AREA)

Lake communities, rolling farmland and quiet roads north of Knoxville with scenic drives and room for acreage.

CLINTON, NORRIS & MAYNARDVILLE

Small towns with historic charm, outdoor recreation and an easy commute to Knoxville and Oak Ridge.

Not sure where you fit? Take the questionnaire and I'll build a short list of areas for you, then we'll tour them together, in person or by video.

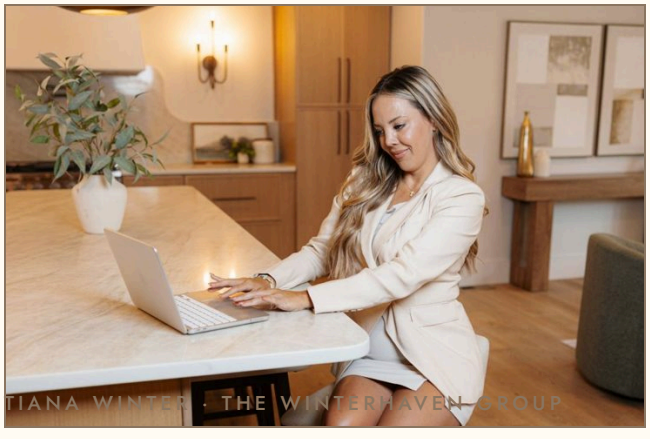
Area descriptions are general and for orientation only; schools, taxes, zoning and conditions change by address. Verify details for any property you consider.

RELOCATING?

MATCH YOUR CURRENT LIFESTYLE

The easiest way to choose is to start with how you live now. Here is where I often point buyers coming from different parts of the country.

IF YOU'RE USED TO...	LOOK AT	WHAT YOU'LL FIND
Big city living (Atlanta, Chicago, NYC, DC)	Downtown, Old City, Sequoyah Hills, Bearden, North Knoxville	Walkable pockets, dining, music, festivals, greenways and a university energy, with far lower density.
Suburban family life (Ohio, Illinois, Georgia, Texas)	Farragut, Hardin Valley, West Knoxville, Maryville	Planned neighborhoods, parks, sports leagues, shopping and well-regarded schools nearby. Verify school zones by address.
Beach & coastal (Florida, the Carolinas, the Gulf)	Lenoir City, Loudon, Dandridge, Norris Lake area	Boating, marinas and waterfront or water-access homes, with four mild seasons.
Mountains & outdoors (Colorado, the West, the Northwest)	South Knoxville, Maryville foothills, Townsend, Sevierville	Trail systems, river and mountain access, the Smokies close by and smaller-town pace.
Rural & farmland (the Midwest, Pennsylvania, upstate)	East and north Knox County, Union, Jefferson, rural Blount and Sevier	Acreage, barns, privacy and open land. Ask about septic, wells, road access and greenbelt tax programs.
Active adult & retirement	Tellico Village, Oak Ridge, Sevierville, Maryville	Golf, clubs, medical access and lock-and-leave options. Many 55+ communities have their own rules and dues.
Tech, research & remote work	Hardin Valley, Oak Ridge, West Knoxville, Downtown	Proximity to the labs and tech employers, home-office-friendly floor plans and reliable internet. Always confirm provider options by address.
Vacation home or investment	Sevierville, Pigeon Forge, Gatlinburg, lake communities	Strong visitor demand, but rental rules, HOA limits and permits differ widely.



COMPARE BY AMENITIES

As we narrow your list we'll compare each area by the things that matter to you: commute, greenways and parks, lake or river access, shopping and dining, medical care, airport access and the feel of the neighborhood.

PROTECT YOUR PLANS

ZONING, RESTRICTIONS & RULES

What you can do with a property is set by more than the deed. Before you fall in love, verify the rules that apply to the exact address. These are the main layers:

LAYER	WHAT TO CHECK
Zoning	City and county zoning decides the allowed uses (residential, agricultural, commercial), lot sizes, setbacks, building height and whether things like a second dwelling, home business or animals are allowed. Knoxville and Knox County are zoned separately, and other counties have their own rules.
HOA, covenants & deed restrictions	Private rules can limit fences, outbuildings, parking, rentals, exterior colors and more, even where zoning allows them. Read the full documents and any recent fee increases or special assessments.
Flood & floodplain	Properties near rivers, creeks and lakes may be in a flood zone, which affects insurance, lender requirements and building. Ask for the flood determination.
Hillside & steep slopes	Some areas limit or add requirements for building on steep or ridge-top land. Important for views and for adding onto a home.
Water & sewer	Public sewer, septic and wells each carry costs and limits. A septic system's size and condition can limit additions or extra bedrooms. Utility districts differ by area.
Easements & access	Utilities, shared driveways and private roads can limit where you build. Ask who maintains the road and how costs are shared. A survey shows boundaries and easements.
Short-term rentals	Rules differ by city and county, and often require permits and have HOA limits. Never assume a home can be rented short term. Verify first.
Agricultural & greenbelt	Tennessee's Greenbelt program can lower taxes on qualifying farm, forest or open-space land (generally 15 or more acres for farm and forest, 3 or more for open space). Changing the land's use can trigger additional taxes, so ask before you buy.
Annexation & growth	Planned roads, developments and annexation can change an area's character and taxes. Check local planning agendas.

Rule of thumb: Put every important plan in writing before you buy, and make the purchase contract contingent on confirming it. I'll help you verify zoning with the local planning office and include the right protections.

EVERY POSSIBILITY FOR YOUR PROPERTY

A home is a place to live, and it can be a place to grow. Decide now what you might want later so you buy a property that can handle it. For each idea, check zoning, HOA rules, utilities and cost.

GUEST HOUSE OR ADU

A garage apartment, backyard cottage or basement suite for family, guests or rental income. Tennessee has recently limited how local governments can restrict ADUs, but HOA and deed rules still apply, so verify the current rules.

HOME OFFICE OR STUDIO

Dedicated space for work or creative projects. Look at layout, internet options and any home-business rules.

WORKSHOP, BARN OR GARAGE

Check lot size, setbacks, deed limits and where utilities run. Some neighborhoods restrict outbuildings.

HOBBY FARM & ANIMALS

Land, fencing, water and zoning for horses, chickens or gardens. Ask about greenbelt eligibility.

LONG-TERM RENTAL

A second property or a portion of your home, with steady rent. Confirm local rules and landlord requirements.

SHORT-TERM RENTAL

Popular near the Smokies and lakes, but heavily regulated in places. Verify permits, HOA limits and local rules first.

ADDITIONS & POOL

Septic limits, setbacks, easements and slope can all affect a bigger footprint. Ask early.

BUILD OR SUBDIVIDE

Land, new construction and splitting lots involve planning approval, utilities and time. Let's review feasibility before you commit.

RESALE & INVESTMENT

Think about who will buy it from you: location, floor plan, schools and amenities that hold value.

AGING IN PLACE

One-level living, wide doorways and easy access make a home work for the long run.

DUE DILIGENCE CHECKLIST

- Confirm zoning with the planning office
- Order a survey if boundaries matter
- Inspect septic, well, roof and HVAC
- Read HOA and deed restrictions
- Check flood zone and insurance quotes
- Get contractor estimates for planned work

GET THE BEST RESULT

NEGOTIATION TACTICS

Winning a home is about more than price. The right strategy depends on the market, the seller's situation and what matters most to you. Here are the tools I use for my buyers.

1. KNOW THE REAL VALUE
We study recent comparable sales, days on market and price changes so your offer is based on facts, not emotion.

2. UNDERSTAND THE SELLER
A relocation, an estate, a second home or a quick move each calls for a different approach. Motivation shapes what they value beyond price.

3. MAKE THE TERMS WORK
Flexible closing dates, a short rent-back, fewer contingencies or a larger earnest deposit can make a lower price more attractive.

4. PROTECT YOUR LEVERAGE
Never reveal your maximum. Keep communication calm and consistent, and be ready to walk away.

5. USE THE INSPECTION WISELY
Ask for repairs or credits on significant issues, not cosmetic ones. Prioritize safety, structure, roof, systems and moisture.

6. ASK FOR HELP WITH COSTS
Seller-paid closing costs, rate buydowns and credits can lower your cash or monthly payment, sometimes more than a price cut.

7. PLAN FOR THE APPRAISAL
If a home appraises low, you can renegotiate, bring more cash, or walk away under your contingency. Decide your plan in advance.

8. MOVE QUICKLY, OFFER CLEARLY
Pre-approval ready, offers written cleanly, and quick responses signal a serious buyer, which matters in competitive situations.

9. GET AGREEMENT IN WRITING
Every request and concession belongs in the contract or an addendum, with dates. Verbal promises don't count.

10. STAY FLEXIBLE, NOT DESPERATE
Good deals come from calm decision-making. Another home will come along if this one doesn't work.

WORKING WITH AN AGENT TODAY

Since August 17, 2024, buyers sign a written agreement with their agent **before touring homes**. It must state how the agent is paid, and commissions are always negotiable. I'll walk you through it line by line so you know exactly what to expect.

YOUR ROAD MAP

FROM FIRST CALL TO THE KEYS

STEP	WHAT HAPPENS
1. Consult	We talk through your goals, timeline and questionnaire.
2. Pre-approval	Meet a lender, review your numbers and set your budget.
3. Buyer agreement	Review and sign before touring, so we're aligned.
4. Search & tour	New-listing alerts, in-person or video tours, area drive-throughs.
5. Offer	Comps, strategy and terms, then negotiation.
6. Under contract	Earnest money, inspection, appraisal, title and survey.
7. Final steps	Closing disclosure review, utilities, insurance, final walkthrough.
8. Closing	Sign, fund, and receive your keys.



Most buyers spend a few weeks to a few months searching, then roughly 30 to 45 days from accepted offer to closing.

CLOSING DAY CHECKLIST

- Government photo ID
- Funds as directed by the title company
- Homeowner's insurance in place
- Utilities in your name
- Final walkthrough complete
- Change of address filed

QUICK GLOSSARY

- **Earnest money:** a good-faith deposit
- **Contingency:** a condition for the sale
- **Appraisal:** opinion of value
- **Escrow:** neutral holding account
- **Closing costs:** fees paid at closing

READY WHEN YOU ARE

LET'S FIND YOUR HOME

Over 300 families have trusted me with their move. Book a call or appointment and let's map out yours.



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General information only, not legal, tax or financial advice. Programs, rates, rules and conditions change; confirm details with your lender, the local planning office and other professionals. Equal Housing Opportunity.